nowhere to be seen. Hadn't he said three o'clock? Maybe he'd been delayed by work at the vineyard.

Another fifteen, then thirty minutes passed. The bells rang once to mark the half hour, and still she stood alone, waiting. Looking out at Rue Jeanne d'Arc with grand buildings on either side and gendarmes patrolling the shops, self-doubt crept in. Maybe now that he'd met her, she was a disappointment. Their conversation on Quai du Roi kept spiraling through her mind. The moment she'd told him she was a cleaner and he'd seen through her sketches that she didn't know basic drawing techniques. Surely, he realized she was uneducated and socially inferior to him. Rose had never studied at L'Ecole des Beaux-Arts. And she never would. How could she have let herself believe that they were at the same level?

By the time the bells rang four o'clock, Rose had convinced herself that he wasn't coming. Not now or ever again. She'd let her mind run away with all sorts of ideas about him that weren't grounded in reality. He'd decided she wasn't the one for him, and she'd been foolish to think otherwise. When he'd seen her at the embankment drawing the bridge, he'd either imagined a version of Rose that didn't exist or was simply trying to do a good deed.

She descended the limestone steps, their midpoints rounded like spoons from centuries of use. The sun no longer warmed her shoulders; instead, it's reflection off the stone blinded her. She turned away from the main road onto a smaller one that would lead to the boardinghouse. She kept moving. It was the only way to handle the turmoil inside.

"Rose . . ." André said, running alongside her.

"André?" She was so surprised by his presence that she couldn't speak.

"I'm sorry. I couldn't go to the cathedral." He was slightly out of breath. "There were gendarmes patrolling nearby . . . I've got a confession to make."

She rolled her eyes, readying herself for an excuse of why they couldn't meet again. "I've got to go," she said. Keep moving. Don't get hurt. Be more like Léa.

"Can you stop and give me a chance to explain?" He touched her hand with gentle hesitation, bringing her to a stop. He let go, but his warmth lingered. "I'm on the run. I didn't realize the gendarmes would be around the cathedral. I couldn't risk them seeing me. I wanted to—"

"Why are they looking for you?"